ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

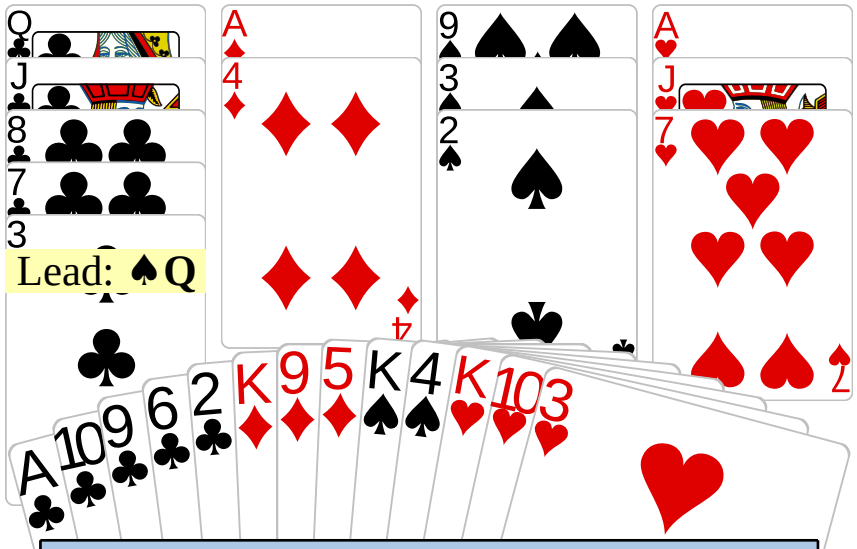
These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

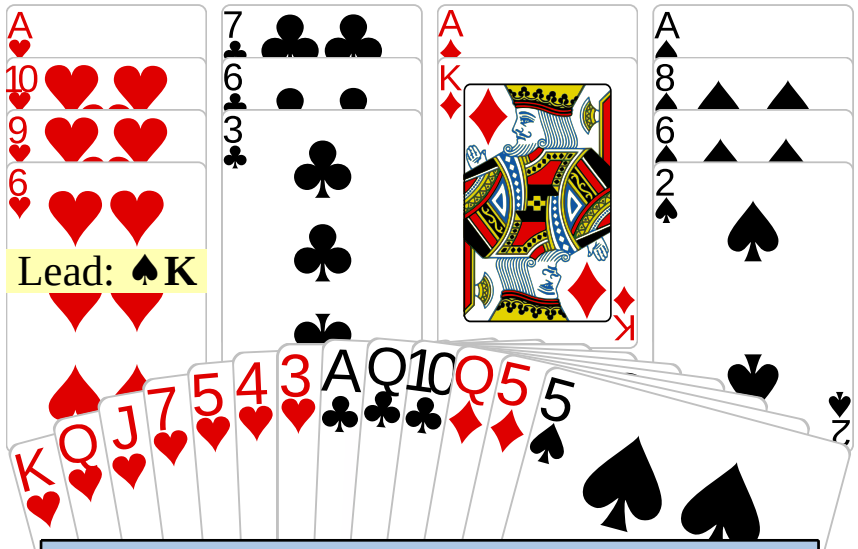
25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **5♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



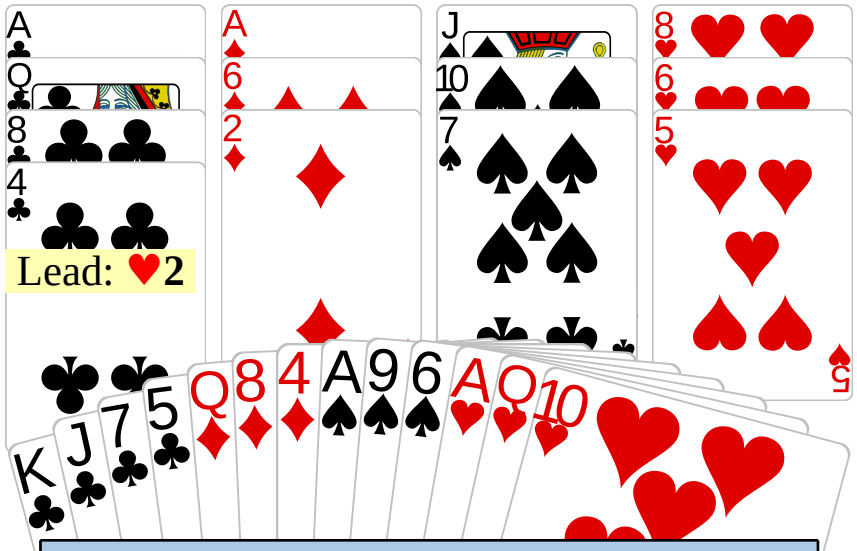
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



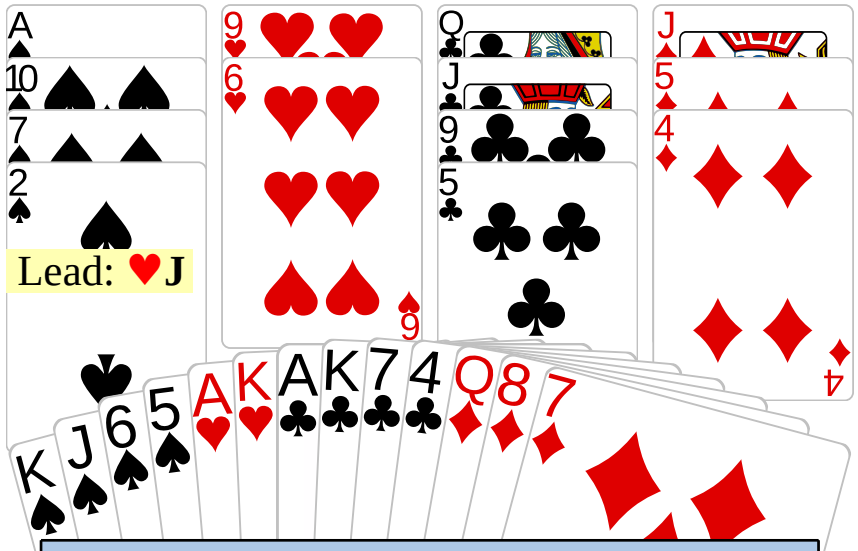
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



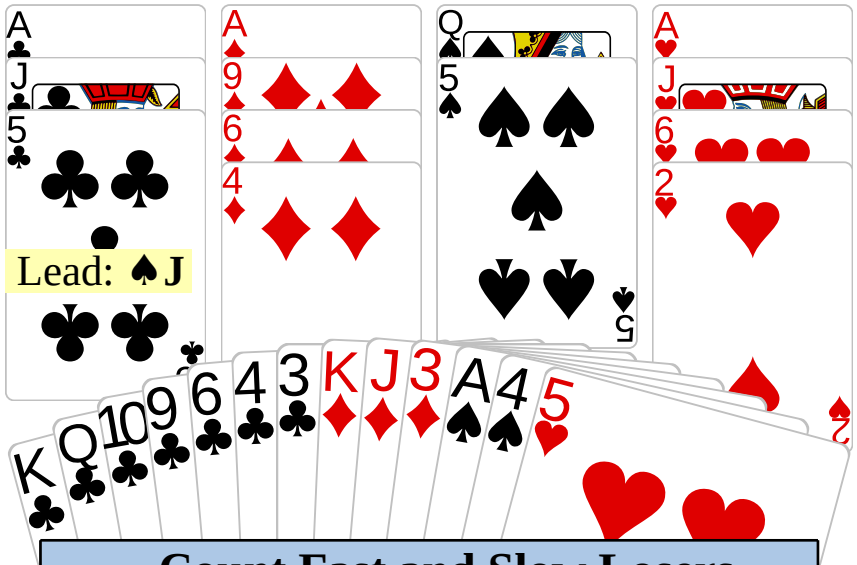
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 5♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥2

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥J

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠J

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 4 ♥ K 10 3 ♦ K 9 5 ♣ A 10 9 6 2	
♠ A 6 5 ♥ Q 9 8 2 ♦ 10 8 7 6 2 ♣ 5	N W E S	♠ Q J 10 8 7 ♥ 6 5 4 ♦ Q J 3 ♣ K 4
	♠ 9 3 2 ♥ A J 7 ♦ A 4 ♣ Q J 8 7 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	1♠	2♠
Pass	3♣	Pass	5♣
All Pass			

5♣ by North
Lead: ♠Q

South's cue-bid shows a limit raise or better (11 points) in ♣s. North is to play 5♣. East leads the ♠Q, West takes the ♠A and returns the ♠6 to your ♠K.

You have lost one trick already and have a possible loser in trumps and another possible loser in ♥s. Both loserscan be avoided with successful finesses. The problem with the ♣ finesse is that East made an overcall so he is more likely to hold the ♣K. If you don't try the ♣ finesse you may be able to throw a defender in with the ♣K at a time when he will have to help you with his next play.

After winning the ♠K immediately play the ♣A.

It would have been nice to see the ♣K fall, but it didn't. So play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A and play the ♠9, ruffing in your hand.

Eliminate the ♦s by playing ♦K, then ruffing your last ♦ in dummy.

You have done all the eliminating, time to throw in somebody.

You play a ♣ to throw East in.

Whichever defender had the ♣K is now on lead, but wishes he wasn't. If he plays a ♥ you get a free finesse. If he plays anything else you get a ruff-sluff.

If you had finessed for the ♣K East would have won the trick and been able to make a safe exit, probably with his other ♣.

You would then have been forced to rely on the ♥ finesse, and with East being the defender who showed some strength, you would likely have finessed through him.

About the only way the elimination/throw-in could fail is if the ♣s split 3-0. Then, if you play Ace and another the defender who wins would use his third ♣ as a safe exit.

Board 2
South Deals
N-S Vul

♠ J 9 7 4
♥ 8
♦ J 9 6 4 3
♣ 9 8 2

♠ A 8 6 2
♥ A 10 9 6
♦ A K
♣ 7 6 3



♠ 5
♥ K Q J 7 5 4 3
♦ Q 5
♣ A Q 10

♠ K Q 10 3
♥ 2
♦ 10 8 7 2
♣ K J 5 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
1NT	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥	Pass	5♣	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠K

Your 3♥ bid is a slam suggestion. After you show the ♣A partner wastes no time in bidding it.

East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠K.

This is a good slam. You have only two possible ♣ losers, and by taking two ♣ finesses you have an excellent chance of success. But by using an elimination play you will have a sure thing.

Win the ♠A and ruff a ♠ with a ♥ honor.

Play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9 and ruff another ♠. Both defenders followed to the trump play.

Play another ♥ to dummy's ♥10 and ruff the last ♠.

Play the ♦A and ♦K.

Conveniently you are in dummy.

North plays low.

You play a ♣ from dummy and insert the ♣10 when North plays low.

South will probably win this trick. If he wins with the ♣K then your hand is good. If he wins with the ♣J then he is end-played, forced to either lead a ♣ into your ♣ A Q or to give you a ruff-sluff.

You probably noticed that you could have finessed your ♣Q on the first ♣ play and pulled off the end-play just as effectively. But there is an advantage to making the first finesse with the ♣10.

If North just happens to hold both the ♣K and ♣J you will make all thirteen tricks if your first finesse is with the ♣10!

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ J 10 7 ♥ 8 6 5 ♦ A 6 2 ♣ A Q 8 4	
♠ K Q 2 ♥ K 9 7 2 ♦ K 7 5 3 ♣ 10 3	N W E S	♠ 8 5 4 3 ♥ J 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 ♣ 9 6 2
	♠ A 9 6 ♥ A Q 10 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ K J 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥2

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥2. East plays the ♥J which you win with the ♥Q.

You have one trick already in the bag, four more to come in ♣s, and three other Aces. So all you have to do it get one of those finesse positions to come through. By now, though, you must have figured that nothing is going to work! Even your best shot, East holding at least one of ♠ K Q will not happen. The answer (again) is to eliminate, then throw in.

This time there is only one suit you can eliminate, ♣s. So play all four ♣s, ending in dummy. They split 3-2.

East plays low.

You play the ♠J from dummy and let it ride when East follows with a low card. (If East had covered you would win the Ace then set up a second trick in the suit.)West wins with the ♠Q, and guess what?

HE IS ENDPLAYED!. He has no ♣s, and whichever other suit he plays will give you your ninth trick!

Wow! End-played at trick #6.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 8 3 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ K 10 6 2 ♣ 10 2	
♠ K J 6 5 ♥ A K ♦ Q 8 7 ♣ A K 7 4		♠ A 10 7 2 ♥ 9 6 ♦ J 5 4 ♣ Q J 9 5
	♠ 9 4 ♥ Q 7 5 3 2 ♦ A 9 3 ♣ 8 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	Pass	3♣	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♥J

West is to play 4♠ after East's Stayman bid uncovered the 4-4 fit. North leads the ♥J which you win the your ♥A.

With three possible losers in ♦s you might first think that you will have to finesse one of the defenders for the trump Queen. But anytime you see an unsupported Jack opposite an unsupported Queen you should start thinking about a throw-in play. And what better card to use for the throw-in than the Queen of trumps.

So pull two rounds of trumps with the ♠A and ♠K, hoping the ♠Q falls. She doesn't fall, but both defenders do follow suit. So the ♠Q is the only trump outstanding.

Next eliminate ♥s from you and dummy by playing the ♥K.

Now play four rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit. If a defender decides to ruff one of these ♣s with the master trump he will be end-played, forced to either play a ♦ or to give you a ruff-sluff. So assume that all four ♣s win tricks.

Now you administer the coup de grace.

You lead a trump.

One of the defenders has won the ♠Q. Too bad for him. If he now plays a ♦ you will make either the ♦Q or ♦J. If he plays a ♥ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♦ loser from the other.

It is clear that the elimination play saved you having to guess the finesse for the ♠Q.

But what if you considered yourself a really good guesser? So good that you felt confident in taking the finesse, and so good that you pulled it off successfully.

You'd be no better off. Although you would avoid the ♠ loser you would now have to play the ♦s for yourself and you would lose three ♦s!

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 4 ♥ 5 ♦ K J 3 ♣ K Q 10 9 6 4 3	
♠ K 8 6 3 ♥ Q 9 8 3 ♦ 10 7 5 ♣ 8 2	N W E S	♠ J 10 9 7 2 ♥ K 10 7 4 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 7
	♠ Q 5 ♥ A J 6 2 ♦ A 9 6 4 ♣ A J 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	4♣
Pass	6♣		
All Pass			

6♣ by North
Lead: ♠J

North considered Blackwood, then realized if South showed either 2 or 3 Aces he was going to bid slam. But if South showed just one Ace he would have to maneuver to play 5NT which might be worse than 6♣. So he just bid the slam. North plays 6♣. East leads the ♠J.

You wish, you hope, you may even pray, but when you play the ♠Q West covers with the ♠K. So you know you have a ♠ loser. And unless West holds the ♦Q you might have a ♦ loser also.

Perhaps an elimination play will improve your chances. Don't lead a trump yet though, you're going to need several entries to dummy to eliminate the ♥s.

Win the ♠, play to the ♥A and ruff a ♥.

Play a trump to dummy's ♣J (both defenders follow) and ruff another ♥ high.

Play to dummy's ♣A, pulling their last trump, and ruff the last ♥.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♠. If East wins the trick he will have to play ♦s for you or give you a ruff-sluff. So if these are competent defenders they will make sure that it is **WEST** who wins the ♠ trick. So he does, and he plays a small ♦.

West leads a small ♦.

DO NOT PLAY THE JACK! If the finesse is going to work now it will still work one trick later. By playing low you take advantage of the possibility that West held the ♦10 and East will have to put on the ♦Q to prevent you taking a trick with dummy's ♦9.

Many elimination endings give you a sure thing. Others just improve your chances.

Here you had two chances. First, East might have HAD to win the throw-in, either because he had all of the high ♠s, or more likely because he messed up. The second chance paid off when West took the throw-in but you found a fortunate position with the ♦s.